

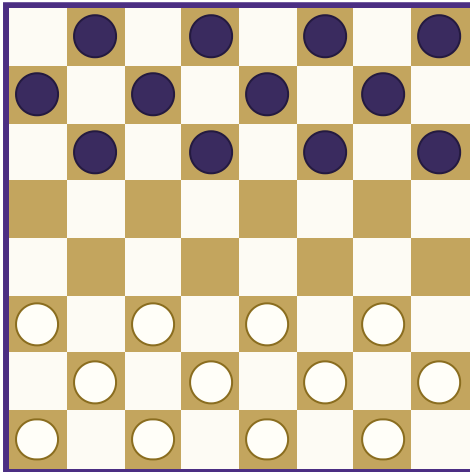
Filipino Dama — Classroom Rules Guide

Filipino Dama (Filipino checkers / *dama*) is the Philippine variant of draughts — a two-player strategy game played on the dark squares of an 8×8 board.

Descended from the Spanish game of damas in the colonial era, dama is still played at plazas, sari-sari stores, and barbershops — often on hand-drawn boards with bottle caps for pieces. No equipment needed: students can draw a board on paper or cardboard.

1 Board Setup

OPPONENT'S SIDE (DARKER PIECES)



YOUR SIDE (LIGHTER PIECES)

Starting position: 12 men each on the dark squares of the three nearest rows.

- The board is **8×8** — the same board used for chess — but the game is played **only on the 32 dark squares**.
- Each player starts with **12 men** (ordinary pieces), placed on the dark squares of the **three rows nearest** that player.
- The **middle two rows start empty**.
- By convention, the player with the **lighter-colored pieces moves first**.

Classroom setup check: before play begins, have partners count aloud — 12 pieces each, all on dark squares, two empty rows in the middle.

2 How Men Move

- A man moves **one square diagonally forward** (toward the opponent) onto an empty dark square.
- Men **never move backward** — but they **can capture backward** (see Rule 3).
- To **capture**, a man jumps over an adjacent enemy piece and lands on the empty square just beyond it — jumping **forward or backward**. The jumped piece is removed.
- **Chain captures:** if the landing square allows another jump, the same piece must keep jumping in the same turn until no more captures are possible.
- During a chain, jumped pieces **stay on the board until the chain ends** — they still block squares — and no piece may be jumped twice.

3 Mandatory Capture — *sapilitang kain*

- If a capture is available, **you must take it** — in Tagalog, *sapilitang kain*, literally “forced eating.”
- If several capture lines are available, you must play the line that **captures the most pieces** (the maximum-capture rule).
- If two or more lines capture the **same highest number**, the player may freely choose between them.

Common beginner mistake: forgetting that ordinary men capture *backward* as well as forward — and missing a longer capture chain that the rules require them to take.

4 The Flying Dama — *lumilipad na dama*

- When a man reaches the **farthest row**, it is crowned a **dama** — a *flying* king (*lumilipad na dama*).
- A dama **slides any number of squares** along an open diagonal, in any diagonal direction.
- It also **captures from range**: it may jump an enemy piece anywhere along its diagonal and land on any empty square beyond it.
- Limits: a dama **cannot jump over its own pieces**, and it **cannot jump two enemy pieces standing directly next to each other**.
- **Mid-chain promotion**: if a man reaches the far row in the middle of a capture chain, it becomes a dama immediately and **continues capturing as a dama in the same turn**.

5 Winning and Draws — *tabla*

- **Win** by capturing all of your opponent's pieces, **or** by leaving your opponent with no legal move.
- A game can end in a **draw**, called *tabla* — including under the **40-move rule**: if 40 consecutive moves pass with no capture and no ordinary man advancing, the game is declared a draw.

6 Filipino Dama vs. American Checkers

RULE	FILIPINO DAMA	AMERICAN CHECKERS
Men capture backward?	Yes — men capture forward and backward	No — men capture forward only
Crowned piece	Flying dama — slides and captures along whole diagonals	King moves and jumps one square at a time
Several captures available	Must take the line capturing the most pieces	May choose any available capture
Promotion during a capture chain	Becomes a dama and keeps capturing that same turn	The turn ends when the man is crowned

7 Quick Quiz

1. How many pieces does each player have at the start, and where are they placed?
2. Can an ordinary man capture backward?
3. You can capture 2 pieces one way or 3 pieces another way. Which capture must you play?
4. What happens when a man reaches the last row, and what special power does it gain?
5. What does *tabla* mean, and name one way it can happen.

ANSWER KEY — TURN THE PAGE UPSIDE DOWN

Answers: 1. 12 men each, on the dark squares of the three rows nearest each player. 2. Yes — men capture both forward and backward, even though they move only forward. 3. The 3-piece capture — the maximum-capture line is mandatory. 4. It is crowned a dama — a flying king that slides any distance diagonally and captures from range. 5. A draw — for example, under the 40-move rule (40 moves with no capture and no man advancing).

Word bank: *sapilitang kain* = mandatory capture (“forced eating”) · *lumilipad na dama* = the flying dama (king) · *tabla* = a draw.